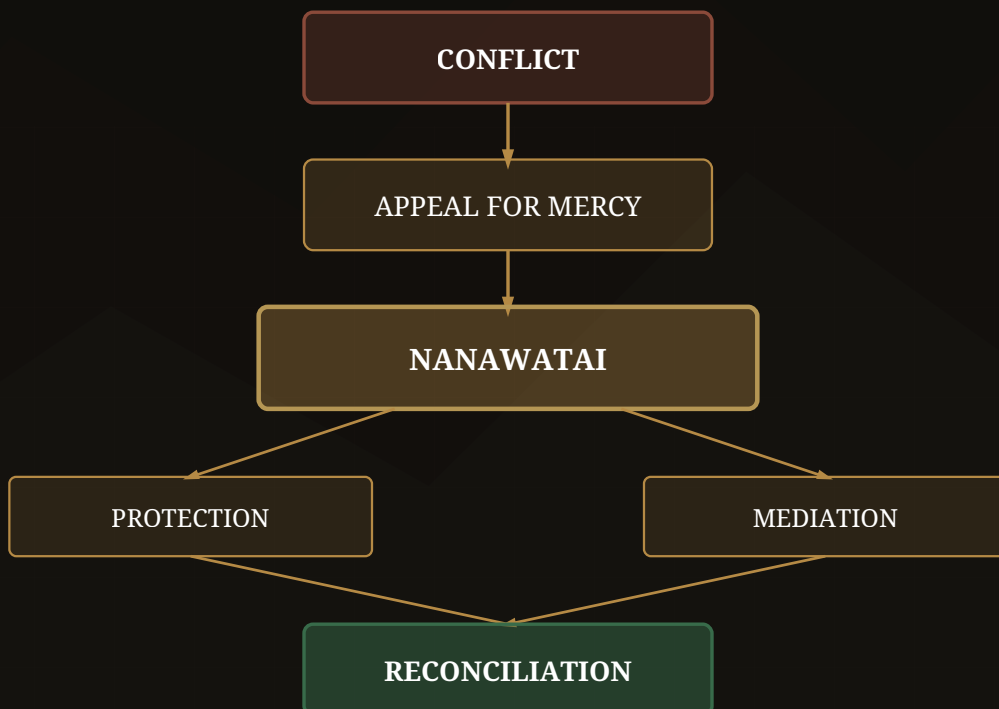


NANAWATAI — PROTECTION & FORGIVENESS

Conflict Appeal Nanawatai Mediation Mercy Reconciliation

Some of the deepest values of a society become visible not when relationships are peaceful, but when they are under strain. Nanawatai belongs to this difficult space.

In scholarly discussions of Pashtun customary practice, *nəṇawāte* is associated with an appeal for protection, assistance, mediation, mercy, or reconciliation. It is not simply a synonym for forgiveness or an absolute legal right. Rather, it is a social process through which a person involved in conflict can make an appeal and seek a way out of continuing hostility.¹



“Nanawatai can create a pathway from conflict toward protection, mediation, and reconciliation.”

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE AND THE DOCUMENTARY RECORD

Importantly, Nanawatai is not merely a modern romanticized description of tribal life. Historical research by scholars such as Mikhail Pelevin demonstrates that *nānawāte* appears in early modern Pashto historical and literary sources—including *Tarikh-i Murasaʿ* (completed in 1724) and *Adam Khan aw Durkhaney* (1706/7). These texts show that the custom was actively debated and practiced in early modern times as a structured mechanism for resolving feuds.²



“Documentary evidence confirms the long historical depth of Nanawatai in Pashto texts.”

NANAWATAI, JIRGA, AND MELMASTIA DISTINGUISHED

To understand Pashtun customary life precisely, Nanawatai must not be confused with related concepts. As noted in *Encyclopaedia Iranica*’s entries on customary assemblies (*jerga*), Nanawatai is an appeal for refuge and conflict resolution; a jirga is the deliberative assembly of

elders that mediates disputes; and Melmastia is general hospitality toward guests. While they share a foundation in social responsibility, their specific contexts differ.³

NANAWATAI

Appeal & Refuge
Seeking Mercy

JIRGA

Assembly of Elders
Mediation & Consensus

MELMASTIA

Hospitality
Welcoming Visitors

“Customary institutions and practices serve distinct yet complementary social functions.”

CONFLICT • APPEAL • MEDIATION • RECONCILIATION

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

For me, the most powerful part of Nanawatai is not the idea of protection alone. It is the possibility of stopping a conflict. There is strength in answering harm, but there can also be strength in choosing not to continue it. A person who asks for mercy has to lower their pride; a person who grants mercy has to control their anger. That is reconciliation.

